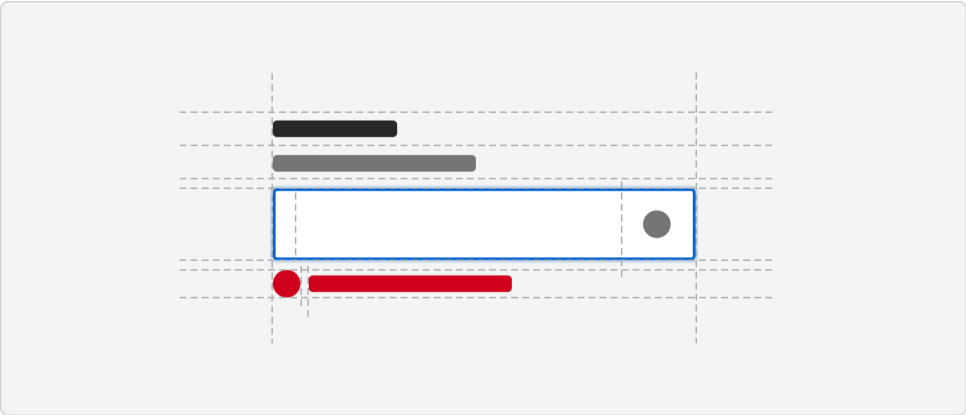
Text Field - Design Rationale

Created by Tony Wang, last modified on 03 Sep 2020



Based on the research findings on Text Field, we've summarised the design rationale behind our Text Field pattern in the Able Design System.

Labels should always be visible.

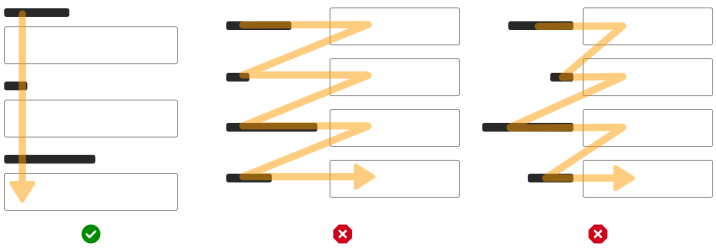
The most important information in a text field is the label. It tells users what input information is required and what information belongs in a given field. Without the labels, users cannot check their input before submitting (Nielsen Norman Group).

Placing labels on the top of the field is recommended.

There are many ways of positioning the field label. The label should:

- Be placed closer to the associated text field than to other text fields (Law of Proximity).
- Not be placed inside the field, eye-tracking studies have proven to be less noticeable.

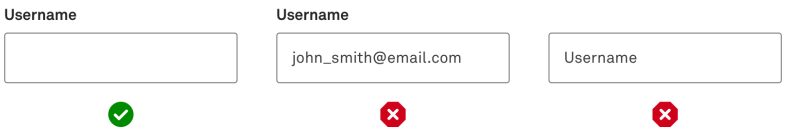
In majority of the cases, placing label on the top of the field is recommended when the page length is not an issue. It's easier for user to scan up and down (compared to scanning left to right with labels on the left) and allows more space for the input area.



Don't use placeholder text.

Placeholder text within a form field causes a number of usability and accessibility issues.

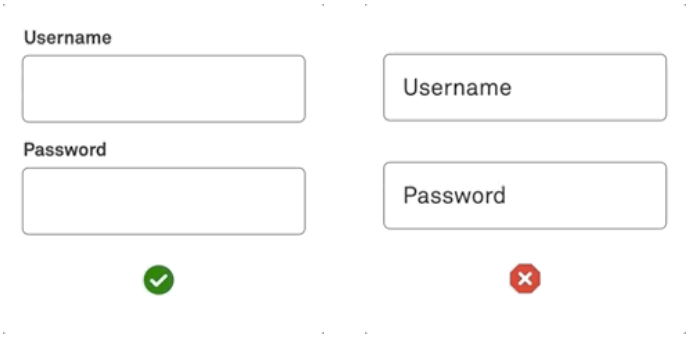
- Appearing and disappearing placeholder text increases the user's memory load.
- Requires additional interactions to reveal placeholder text again by clicking in and out of text field.
- Not always accessible to a screenreader
- Low colour contrast (which can mislead users to think the placeholder text is an entry)



Don't use floating labels.

A floating label is an enhanced version of placeholder text. It addresses the issue of placeholder disappearing and appearing and it also save space by not requiring extra vertical space to put the label above the field. However, there are still problems with this approach:

- Fields with text in them are less noticeable, and users might think there is already a default value entered in the field.
- Animating text is harder to read.

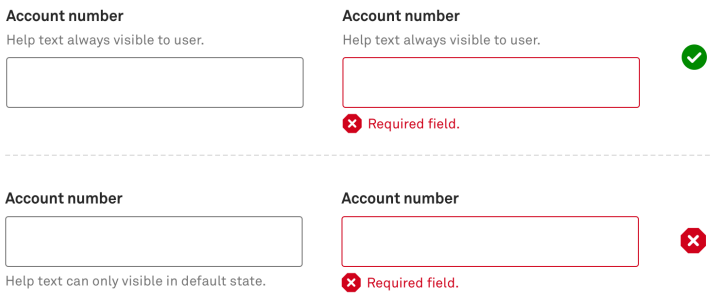


Help Text should be always visible when displaying important information.

Help text is designed to display only the critical information to guide users. Avoid displaying secondary or unnecessary information to reduce a user's cognitive load. See more in our Content Guidelines on Help Text.

There are several advantages placing Help Text on top of text field instead of placing underneath the field.

- Important info is shown to users before they begin typing (top-down reading direction).
- It's always visible (including when text field is in error state), so our users don't need to memorise or hunt for instructions.
- Visible help text on screen means it's also available for screenreaders where content is not loss when text field is in error state.
- Help text is placed close to the label and text field than to other text fields. This is also following Law of Proximity.
- Help text isn't blocked by browser's auto-filled menu or on-screen keyboards on mobile devices.



Make error highly visible and noticeable.

When an error has occurred in Text Field, it should be highly visible and noticeable to the users (including screenreader users). It should:

- Be easy for the user to notice and locate the text field with the error.
- Present the error with a variety of visual cues (an icon, bold font, colour, or background colour).
- Highlight the error state in the label attribute for screen reader users.
- Use iconography to stand out and draw user's attention to the error text. This will also help users with colour blindness to identify what needs to be fixed.
- Not hide error text under a tooltip (or under any other element) to report errors. A user may end up wondering what's wrong with a text field without realising that they need to perform an additional step to actually surface the error text.

Box-shape Text Fields are more effective than line-style.

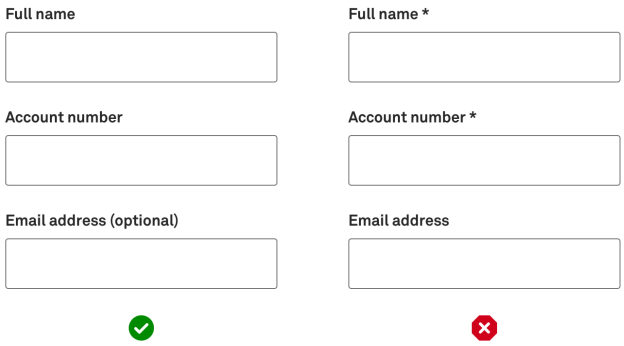
Google Design has published a comprehensive study about the Text Field in Material Design. The user study has proven the text field with box-shape performed better in identifiability and findability than those using a line affordance.

Mark Optional Fields instead of Required Ones.

One of the principles of designing an effective form is to have a clear understanding of why you need the information and only asked what's necessary from users. If you ask only the necessary information, the majority of fields in your form will be mandatory. Marking every required fields becomes repetitive, it increases visual clutter and user's cognitive load. In addition, the wording 'optional' is more friendly than 'required' or the asterisk character.

Why marking optional fields is better than required ones:

1. Clearer communication
    - The author of Web Form Design book states clearly that not everyone understand what asterisk (*) mean, and they will have to spend time hunting for explanation.
    - An article from NNG explains that users don't read or and likely to forget the asterisk explanation when placed at the top of forms.
    - Adding (optional) at the end of the label makes it easy to read and visually connected to the label that it is referring to.
2. More positive and friendly tone
    - The wording "*Optional*" could give users the power to believe that they have the choice (aligned to NNG's Usability Principle of User Control and Freedom)
    - The wording "*Required*" may make users felt they are trapped and much more restrictive for their brain.
3. Less visual clutter
    - When majority fields are required, adding asterisk becomes repetitive and increase visual clutter.
    - Repetitive content increases user cognitive loads.



Match Text Field to the expected input size.

The width of the text field box serves as a useful guide on how much text users are expected to enter into the field.

- Text field width sets user expectation.
- It communicates how much input is required as users enter their input value.

If we know the length of the expected input, it's recommended to match the width to the expected input when possible.

No labels

Atlassian